

Essays

1. *Describe yourself.*

I am a 26-year-old White, gay male born in St. Augustine, Florida, and raised in a small Southeastern U.S. town. Music is my primary hobby, and I play piano in my spare time. I have three half-siblings on my mother's and father's sides and two step-siblings; I am the only child my parents had together. My upbringing consisted of commuting between my mother's and father's houses, as they were divorced and remarried. As a child, I was mischievous, constantly attempting to annoy my brothers. Yet, at the same time, I was neurotic, as I was preoccupied with innocuous things harming me, like getting diabetes from one cookie or a tornado forming from a single dark cloud.

I remain relatively neurotic, worrying about trivial matters, but I have learned to channel this trait into supporting my conscientiousness. I am prompt and thorough in my academic work and job duties – often falling victim to perfectionism. On a spectrum, I am roughly 80% open to new experiences, whereas the remaining 20% accounts for my need for consistency and routine. For example, I frequently introspect my beliefs about the world, which consequently led me to become an atheist after years of being a zealous Christian. However, I simultaneously have rigid aspects, like where and what I eat. I tend to be highly agreeable and make new friends easily, yet I have times when I withdraw and shun people. In those friendships, I value humility, honesty, mutual respect, and, importantly, humor.

2. *Describe someone you know well.*

Daniel is a 42-year-old White male born in Sacramento, California, and raised in various countries during adolescence and young adulthood (i.e., the U.S., Spain, the U.K., and Ireland). He identifies as an atheist, has one sister, and is married to a 32-year-old man named Charles.

Daniel moved to New York City at the age of 26 and has been living in Harlem ever since, working in the hospitality industry.

Characterologically, Daniel describes himself as “shy”; however, his behavior suggests he is more socially unreserved than he professes. For example, he frequently converses with strangers on an elevator and tends to be relatively domineering in decision-making interpersonally. Daniel is highly scrupulous with everyday tasks, like cooking, and presents himself as poised and well-mannered to others. His willingness to experience novelty is high, although he is somewhat inflexible when challenged on his perspectives. He experiences little negative emotionality and tends to be a predominantly upbeat person with a positive outlook, endorsing statements like “I enjoy life.”

Although he identifies as being on the autism spectrum, Daniel is adept at perceiving others’ moods and emotions and responds to situations accordingly. Daniel, with his cerebral approach to life's stressors, exhibits evidence of strong executive functioning, characterized by high fluid and crystallized intelligence. While watching movies, Daniel will often accurately predict how the plot will unfold, and he can proficiently synthesize and apply complex, novel information quickly. He is additionally able to recall numerous facts and knows obscure words.

3. *Describe how that person would describe you.*

Daniel will likely describe me as I described above, albeit with minor differences. First and foremost, he will lovingly remark about my “short” height (5’7”) and say I have a nice smile with charming curly brown hair and pretty hazel eyes. Since I am from the Southeast U.S., he would amusingly comment on many of my Southern attributes, like how I say “y’all” or like to eat boiled peanuts. Daniel will describe me as someone who drinks too much coffee and spends too much money on eating out instead of cooking at home. He loves to listen to me play piano, so I assume he will detail me as a talented musician.

He might perceive my moments of distance and “closing in” as being cold, but he will also know there is no maliciousness behind them. Daniel would also say I am a deep thinker about philosophical topics like free will or ethics, but it can be annoying when playing devil’s advocate on sensitive subjects. Interpersonally, he would say I am outgoing and socially intelligent, often making quirky jokes that are only funny because they are poor. Professionally, Daniel would say I am hardworking and effective at working with people, critically thinking about solutions to problems, and very goal-oriented. He might note that I can be stubborn regarding my independence; I typically insist on relying on myself monetarily.